Unbeknownst to most of its inhabitants, the world entered a new and dangerous era on August 2, 2019. On that day the planet's strongest nuclear powers, the United States and Russia, with thirty thousand warheads between them, declared their withdrawal from the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces Treaty signed by Ronald Reagan and Mikhail Gorbachev in 1987. Until that day the treaty was the last Cold War–era arms-control agreement still remaining in place. We are now officially at the start of an uncontrolled nuclear arms race. What it might bring became clear on August 8, less than a week after the Reagan-Gorbachev agreement was abandoned. The reactor of a nuclear-powered and nuclear-armed Russian cruise missile, codenamed Skyfall, exploded in the Barents Sea, killing five Russian scientists and naval officers and contaminating the atmosphere and waters in the Arkhangelsk region of Russia. The ultimate target of Skyfall, as President Putin demonstrated in a public video a year earlier, was the United States.[8]

What we are witnessing today has been characterized by some authors as the arrival of the "second nuclear age." But we are in a more dangerous and unpredictable world today than we were during the Cold War because more powers are prepared to threaten adversaries with nuclear weapons, and the fear of such weapons acquired in the first decades of the Cold War has been considerably dulled. We unlearned the lessons of the past. To survive in the current nuclear age, we must learn them anew.[9]

---

* An acronym for the Executive Committee of the National Security Council convened during the Cuban missile crisis.